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The Tantrum Toolkit

Before, during and after · Ages 2–4

Tantrums are a normal part of development, especially between ages 2 and 3. You can't prevent every one, but you can make them shorter, rarer and less scary for everyone.

What the research says

- ○ Tantrums are very common in toddlers and typically include anger and distress in a predictable pattern (Potegal & Davidson, 2003).
- ○ The brain regions that control impulses and calm emotions mature slowly through childhood (Siegel & Bryson, 2011).

Before (prevent)

- ○ Watch for hunger, tiredness and overstimulation
- ○ Give warnings before transitions
- ○ Offer two choices
- ○ Plan outings around naps and meals

During (stay calm)

- ○ Keep them safe; move breakable things away
- ○ Use few, calm words: “I'm here.”
- ○ Hold the limit: “I won't let you hit.”
- ○ Don't try to reason until they're calm

After (connect and teach)

- ○ Hug or sit together
- ○ Name it: “You were so angry when we left the park.”
- ○ Teach: “Next time you can stamp your feet or tell me 'I'm mad'.”

When to check

Talk to your paediatrician if tantrums are very frequent, long (over 25 minutes), or involve self-injury.

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Potegal, M., & Davidson, R. J. (2003). Temper tantrums in young children: 1. Behavioral composition. Journal of Developmental & Behavioral Pediatrics, 24(3), 140–147.
Siegel, D. J., & Bryson, T. P. (2011). The Whole-Brain Child. Delacorte Press.

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